Understand your feelings. Live with intention.

living well.

a short guide to
emotional wellness



BY

Tola Oladiji



living well.

A Short Guide to Emotional Wellness

TOLA OLADIJI

Living Well: A Short Guide to Emotional Wellness

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A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

This book offers general information and coaching-style guidance on emotional wellness. It is not medical, psychological or therapeutic advice, and it is not a substitute for care from a qualified professional. If you are struggling, please speak to a doctor, therapist or counsellor. If you are in crisis or in danger, contact your local emergency services right away.

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BEFORE WE BEGIN

Introduction

Our lives are ruled by our emotions. From our first day out of the womb to our last day on earth, we are constantly moving through a spectrum of feelings and emotions – both positive and negative. Whether we feel angry at someone who jumps the ATM queue, or we feel happy when we get a credit alert, we really cannot escape our emotions.

But being able to feel can be a great disadvantage to us, if we don't learn how they work because our feelings will always influence our behaviors every day, either consciously or subconsciously. For example, you may have noticed that you are unable to focus on work after a terrible argument with your partner, or after having a really bad spat with your boss, you find yourself transferring that aggression to your loved ones at home.

The reality is that our emotional health or wellness is determined by how we approach the full spectrum of emotions that come with life. That's why an understanding of emotional wellness is very important if we want to live productive lives.

Some people do a great job at finding their way through the complex emotions of everyday life. They know when to express their displeasure at an event and yet not allow that event mar the rest of the day. They are adept at compartmentalizing and expressing the necessary feelings.

For some other people, emotions are a struggle for them, and expressing whatever emotions they feel without being limited by them is like rocket science. If you're in that category, this book is for you.



CHAPTER ONE

What is emotional wellness?

What is emotional wellness

Emotional wellness describes a state of being that includes having a **positive attitude**, a **high self-esteem**, **a strong sense of self** and the ability to **recognize** and **share** a wide range of feelings (positive and negative) with others in a constructive way.

It is also the ability to **respond resiliently and effectively** to **changing emotional states**, and **effectively cope** with situations that present **challenges and obstacles** in life.

I know that may sound a bit technical, so you can put it this way, emotional wellness is a state where a person is able to accept and manage feelings through challenges and change.

Someone who is emotionally healthy can process their emotions correctly. They are able to *respond intentionally* to life's situations rather than just *reacting arbitrarily*.

I should also mention that the concept of emotional wellness lies within that of mental health. The lack of emotions does not mean emotional health, just as the absence of mental illness does not equate to mental health. So, someone suppressing emotions, especially from childhood, may not be as emotionally healthy as someone vulnerable enough to express their emotions.

In a nutshell, emotional wellness is:

- Living well despite problems or challenges in lives i.e. mood stability in both good and bad situations
- Living life to its fullness by finding the good in each day
- Refusing to be defined by your emotions

- Choosing your response to things that happen

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*Emotional wellness is more of a journey than a destination. This journey involves 3 important parts – **awareness, understanding** and **acceptance** of your feelings.*

Why is emotional wellness important?

Emotional wellness affects every area of your life, and if you don't learn how to improve yours, you may end up shortchanging yourself in terms of your productivity and performance.

- **It can affect your physical health**

  Emotional states can show up as physical symptoms. For example, heartbreak may show up as a pain in the chest, depression may manifest in the form of intense lethargy and fatigue. Some people also report an upset stomach as a symptom of anxiety.

  Emotional distress also leaves people susceptible to physical illness. Some studies have shown that ailments like cardiovascular disease and immune system suppression can be linked to emotional distress.

- **It can affect your mental health**

  When you are overwhelmed by emotions, you may observe an inability to process information accurately on occasions you

need to, e.g. when studying or working. Poor emotional health may also make you more susceptible to certain mental health conditions. For example, people with a pessimistic explanatory style are more likely to be clinically depressed than people with an optimistic explanatory style.

- **It can impact the quality of your relationships with others**

  Social interaction and relationships are a necessary part of daily life. People who have optimal emotional health can appropriately interact with others, whether in times of stress or in times of peace. However, when you are emotionally unhealthy, you are not much of a great person to be around which may lead to people avoiding you.

- **It can influence your energy levels**

  People who have a sense of purpose and a positive outlook on life are more likely to be energized as they go about life. On the other hand, poor emotional health will drain you and lead to a state of mental and emotional exhaustion.

- **It can affect your productivity and creativity**

  If you are in a state of poor emotional health, then your creativity and productivity is very likely to be impaired as you may find yourself being submerged under the weight of your feelings without knowing how to process them appropriately.

- **It can impact your resilience**

  Good emotional health is a core part of resilience. I have found that people in emotional distress are more vulnerable when hit

by setbacks and challenges. Not particularly because of the intensity of the challenges, but as a result of insufficient capacity to deal with these challenges.

- **It helps you develop higher self-esteem**

  How you feel about yourself is a direct function of your emotions, thoughts and experiences. When you are emotionally healthy, you understand yourself for who you are, and you have a greater awareness of your abilities which increases your self-esteem.

- **It can foster personal growth**

  When you know how to manage your thoughts and emotions, you are more likely to make better life decisions. But beyond this, you also become more productive, as you become better at focusing on and achieving your goals.

- **It can aid addiction recovery**

  When people have not learned how to respond to stress, they end up turning to unhelpful coping mechanisms like drugs and alcohol. In addiction treatment, they are taught how to process their emotions in times of stress, reducing their dependence on the addictive substances.

IN SHORT

Emotional wellness is not the absence of feeling. It is choosing your response to what happens, and it grows through three things: awareness, understanding and acceptance of your feelings. It shapes your body, mind, relationships, energy, resilience and growth.



CHAPTER TWO

Recognizing the signs

Signs you are emotionally unhealthy

1. You don't love yourself.
2. You have self-limiting thought patterns and behavioral habits.
3. You don't believe in yourself.
4. You are harsh and critical with yourself.
5. Most of the relationships around you are toxic.
6. You allow external possessions and material things determine your self-worth.
7. You consciously or unconsciously seek out people or situations that tell you that you are unlovable and unimportant.
8. You have a pessimistic outlook on life.
9. You suppress your emotions.
10. You use busyness as a way to distract yourself from processing your emotions.
11. You feel bad about feeling bad.
12. You are always seeking comfort and reassurance from others.
13. You harbor anger and resentment in your heart towards people.
14. You have difficulty managing or controlling your temper.
15. You don't know how to deal with stress.

> *When your emotional health is in danger, the most important thing you can do is to seek help. If you or someone you know shows some of these signs of being emotionally unhealthy, coaching is a great place to start. A coach will teach you how to implement keystone habits that help you develop better emotional health.*

Signs you are emotionally healthy

1 You are aware of your emotions

Self-awareness is a strong pointer to emotional wellness. It is being able to embrace your emotions, both positive and negative, as a natural and normal part of life. People who are self-aware are able to handle and acknowledge difficult emotions without becoming overwhelmed by them or denying that they exist. This ability develops throughout the lifetime and is strengthened with continuous use.

True emotional health comes from being able to label, acknowledge and accept tough emotions, but also move forward from them without getting stuck. For example, you might get nervous before going to give a speech, but you don't let the nerves stop you from going out.

2 You practice self-acceptance

Self-awareness goes hand in hand with self-acceptance. Self-acceptance means having an awareness of your strengths and weaknesses, and feeling satisfied with yourself, regardless of whatever flaws you have or bad choices you have made. It means embracing all that you are without exception.

Self-acceptance doesn't mean you don't work on your weaknesses. On the contrary, your journey to improvement only really starts when you accept every part of yourself, good and bad, with no conditions attached.

3 You are intentional about self-care

People who are emotionally healthy show high levels of self-care. Self-compassion and care for one's physical body are important to people who also place importance on emotional health. This self-care is intentional and regularly practiced.

4 You treat other people with kindness and compassion

An emotionally healthy person treats others with kindness and integrity. They do so without expectation of reward. They interact with the people around them with decency and compassion. Psychologists call this prosociality. It means being sensitive to the needs and feelings of other people and thinking it's important to help others.

5 You like yourself for who you are

You may have heard it said before that comparison is the thief of joy. People who are emotionally healthy recognize this and avoid comparing themselves to other people. They have an accurate assessment of their own personal strengths and consider them to be just as important as those possessed by other people.

6 You practice gratitude

Gratitude is about focusing on the positive. Practicing gratitude is a way of purposefully looking at your life with a sense of appreciation for what you have, rather than focusing on what you

are lacking. Emotionally healthy people understand that and practice gratitude for who they have and what they have.

7 You lead a life of purposefulness

An emotionally healthy person is someone who lives with purpose. Leading a purposeful life is about having a passion, a mission or larger meaning to life. The lives of such people have meaning, and they see the bigger picture. People like this think about their inner experiences less and focus on how their experiences can serve others.

8 You place more value on experiences over possessions

People who tend to highly value attaining wealth, being popular, or staying attractive tend to be less emotionally healthy than people who value self-fulfillment and being there for others. Not that there is anything bad about wealth, fame or beauty but, if you place too much value on things like that, you are likely to reach a state where it's never enough to satisfy you.

Experiences may be more meaningful than possessions because they enhance bonding with people, help you enjoy the beauty in the world, and cultivate the positive emotions that come with new experiences.

9 You are flexible

Emotionally healthy people are able to adapt to all kinds of situations that life throws at them. They have the ability to assess a situation mindfully and then use these factors to decide what the best course of action is. If you are flexible, you approach life and relationships with a sense of openness and curiosity, know-

ing that you might need to adjust your course of action when one strategy isn't working.

IN SHORT

Notice the pattern, not just the moment. Suppressing feelings, staying busy to avoid them and being harsh on yourself are signs to act on. Self-awareness, self-acceptance, gratitude, kindness and flexibility are signs of health. If you recognise several unhealthy signs, coaching is a great place to start.



CHAPTER THREE

How do I improve my wellness?

Being emotionally healthy is of utmost importance. We all want to live happy lives, and you're no exception. The good news is that you can influence your own emotional health by picking up new habits that help you develop emotional wellness.

Tips on improving emotional wellness

1 Develop awareness of your emotions

Emotional awareness is being able to recognize and make sense of your emotions. When you know exactly how you feel, you can learn from them. To develop emotional awareness, try asking yourself questions like *What am I feeling right now? Why am I feeling this way?*

2 Learn emotional regulation

Emotional regulation is being able to exert some form of control over your emotional responses. It is the ability to reduce or enhance your emotions as the situation arises. In negative emotional states, ***choose*** to let it go.

3 Identify your strengths

When you know your strengths and use them frequently, you are more likely to have success in several areas. You will feel happier, have better self-esteem, and be more likely to accomplish your goals. However, to use your strengths effectively, it's important to have a clear idea of what they are, and how they can be used. Some of your greatest strengths might be easy to

recognize, while others go unnoticed because they feel ordinary to you (even if they aren't).

4 Practice cognitive reappraisal

Cognitive reappraisal is a psychological strategy that involves choosing a different perspective when looking at negative events that cannot be changed. By reframing your perception of such events, you can reduce their emotional impact. One way to practice this is to ask yourself, *Is there another way I can think about this?* (Problems aren't the problems; it's how you see them, so look for the good in that thing).

5 Take responsibility for your own happiness

Your happiness is your personal responsibility. Don't relinquish that choice to anybody else. People and things can be enjoyable but resist transferring responsibility for your happiness to them. In the same light too, resist blaming others for your unhappiness. Your background and circumstances may influence who you are, but you are responsible for who you become.

6 Manage your expectations of others

Unrealistic expectations of the behavior of other people may lead to disappointment and even feelings of failure. So, it's important that you keep them grounded in reality. Some people may never like you or treat you right, accept that reality about them and choose not to hold resentment in your heart.

7 Accept your mistakes and move on

Mistakes are rather inevitable in life. You will make a lot of them. Accept that as a life truth and you will make much more

progress in your emotional health. Every day you wake up, choose not to dwell on your past regrets or beat yourself over your mistakes. Just learn the lessons you need to learn and move on. You must be as kind, comforting, understanding, and forgiving with yourself as you would be with the people you love the very most.

8 Develop positive relationships

No man is an island, and if you want to live well, you must develop strong, high quality relationships with other people. You don't need to have a million friends, you just need a small core of people that you can depend on to support you emotionally in your difficult times. Learning to trust those around you and allowing them to support you is also very vital.

9 Manage your stress

Learn how to effectively cope with stressors in life. Don't wait till you burn out. Through effective time management, physical exercise, and acceptance that there will be things that we cannot control; you can effectively reduce your stress level.

10 Learn to laugh

Find humor however you can. Laughter has been proven to be medically good, so practice it often! Research shows that it can boost your immune system, ease pain, relax your body, and reduce stress.

11 Practice mindfulness

Mindfulness refers to a state of being where one *chooses* to focus on the present, i.e. you are fully aware of what is happening

right now. With mindfulness, you are deciding to let go of the regrets of the past or anxieties about the future. It's been proven to be effective at reducing stress and increasing concentration.

12 Practice gratitude

Practicing gratitude helps create a habit where we focus on the positive in life. Studies show that gratitude has a powerful effect on mental wellbeing by making us happier and healthier. Among other benefits, it helps reduce stress, increase happiness, and improve self-esteem. Gratitude has two stages, one is the acknowledgement of the good in your life, and the other is recognizing that some of the sources of this good are other people.

13 Take good care of your body

We cannot separate the health of the mind from the health of the body. Just as emotional difficulty can contribute to physical illness, many physical problems contribute to emotional distress and can be avoided by a combination of a healthy diet, regular exercise, and good sleeping habits.

14 Release anger and resentments

Yes, people may have hurt you. But you must let go of your anger and resentment towards them, for your own good. This doesn't mean you are saying that it is okay that people have hurt you; it simply means you are willing to acknowledge that you are neither in charge of others' behaviors nor their punishment, that you are willing to love yourself enough to let go of the toxic waste of anger and resentment that is poisoning your mind, spirit, and probably your body, as well.

Lifestyle changes that promote emotional wellness

- Join stress management classes around you. This will help to reduce the risk of many diseases like depression, heart disease, diabetes.
- Register for therapy sessions with a therapist or coach who can teach you how to function better with your emotions.
- Attend emotional health related seminars and activities to become aware of how to think positive and remain balanced in every stage of life.
- Do things which can make a positive impact on others like volunteering in organizations that serve the less privileged.
- Get enough rest for at least 6 to 8 hours sleep every night. When you sleep, you give your body a chance to replenish itself.
- Embrace good and healthy eating habits. Eat healthy and nutritious food like green vegetables and fruits to keep your body and mind active and stress free.
- Exercise more often to relieve stress. Endorphins are released in the body when we exercise, and they help to reduce stress and increase the feeling of happiness.
- Spend more time with people around you. You can join social communities around you like clubs, church groups etc.
- Avoid use of alcohol, cigarettes, and other drugs which decrease the brain activity that are directly related to emotions.

IN SHORT

Small, regular habits move your emotional health: name what you feel, reframe what you cannot change, take responsibility for your own happiness, look after your body, and release anger and resentment.



CHAPTER FOUR

A final word

Benefits of embracing emotional wellness

1. It helps you correct negative thinking and behavior patterns.
2. It helps you go through life better equipped to deal with the difficulties that will arise.
3. It helps you increase your sense of self-confidence.
4. It helps you develop self-control and improve your concentration level.
5. It helps you improve your social skills and build stronger connections with other people.
6. It makes you more productive.
7. It keeps you emotionally balanced and stable.
8. You are able to identify desires or aims in life, take positive actions which can help to fulfill desires and can make changes in life.
9. It helps you heal from stress, anxiety, and depression.
10. It helps you develop a full life with new vision and purpose.

4 final tips on improving emotional health

1 Give it time

Emotional health is not something anyone can realize overnight. It took your entire life to develop your current emotional understanding. It will also take time to develop the cogni-

tive, behavioral and lifestyle habits that contribute to emotional wellness.

2 Learn from mistakes

It can be very tough to change your already existing patterns of unhelpful emotional behavior, and you're likely to make mistakes. But the important thing is to learn from them. When you are triggered by an event that causes an inappropriate emotional response like anger, learn from it. Reflect on what you can do differently the next time you're faced with this trigger.

3 Cultivate kindness and empathy

Every other human being around you is experiencing emotions too. Developing a compassionate outlook when interacting with others permits them to experience their own emotions too. Best of all, it also leaves room for allowing yourself to be human.

4 Practice forgiveness

Some people find it emotionally releasing to forgive themselves and others who have done them harm. Choosing not to judge yourself for your failings and shortcomings can allow you to develop an outlook on life that is emotionally healthy. Forgiveness towards others can also make room for emotions to move, if they are stuck.

IN SHORT

Give it time, learn from your mistakes, be kind and forgive. Emotional wellness is a journey, not a destination.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Your first week

Seven small steps, one a day, drawn from the tips in this book. Tick each one off as you go. Tap a box to check it on screen, or print the page.

DAY 1

Name it

Ask yourself: *What am I feeling right now? Why am I feeling this way?*

DAY 2

Know your strengths

Write down three strengths, including ones that feel ordinary to you.

DAY 3

Practise gratitude

Note three good things in your life and one person who helped make them possible.

DAY 4

Reframe

Pick one thing you can't change and ask: *Is there another way I can think about this?*

DAY 5

Care for your body

Move your body, eat well and aim for 6 to 8 hours of sleep tonight.

DAY 6

Connect

Spend time with someone in your small core of supportive people.

DAY 7

Let go

Release one resentment. Forgive one mistake, yours or someone else's.

APPENDIX

Test, reflect, practise

Test for emotional wellness

The emotional dimension involves recognizing, accepting and taking responsibility for your feelings.

Read each statement carefully and respond honestly. Type your score in each box and the total will add up for you.

2 Almost always · **1** Sometimes / occasionally · **0** Very rarely

1	I am able to develop and maintain close relationships.	
2	I accept the responsibility for my actions.	
3	I see challenges and change as opportunities for growth.	
4	I feel I have considerable control over my life.	
5	I am able to laugh at life and myself.	
6	I feel good about myself.	
7	I am able to appropriately cope with stress and tension and make time for leisure pursuits.	
8	I am able to recognize my personal shortcomings and learn from my mistakes.	
9	I am able to recognize and express my feelings.	
10	I enjoy life.	
	Total for emotional wellness	

15 to 20 points	Excellent strength in this dimension.
9 to 14 points	There is room for improvement. Look again at the items in which you scored 1 or 0. What changes can you make to improve your score?
0 to 8 points	This dimension needs a lot of work. Look again at this dimension and challenge yourself to begin making small steps toward growth here.

Discussion questions and journal

Take your time. Type your answers on screen or print the pages and write by hand. There are no right answers, only honest ones.

1 Do you see the signs of emotional unhealthiness in yourself?

2 Which of the signs of emotional healthiness are most pronounced in you?

3 Which ones are the least pronounced in you? How can you improve them?

4 Do the people closest to you provide unconditional positive support to you?

5 **Mention any three tips on emotional wellness you will commit to practice this week.**

6 **Who is one person you want to share what you've learnt with? Why?**

7 **What test questions did you score lowest on? How can you improve on that?**

7-day practice tracker

Tick a box each day you practise a habit. Notice what gets easier. Repeat the week as often as you like.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Asked “What am I feeling?”	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Practised gratitude	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Moved my body	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Slept 6 to 8 hours	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Did one kind thing	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Laughed or paused mindfully	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯

One win this week

One thing I will do differently next week

THE AUTHOR

About the author



Tola Oladiji is a strategy consultant and author with a background in psychology and coaching. His professional experience spans consulting, financial services, healthcare, and technology, helping organizations solve complex problems, manage change, and turn plans into results.

Beyond his professional work, Tola has a longstanding interest in how people think, grow, and navigate everyday life. His writing explores emotional wellness, personal development, and faith, offering practical reflections to help readers understand themselves, build healthier relationships, and live with greater purpose.

Tola holds a B.Sc. in Psychology from Obafemi Awolowo University, Ile-Ife, with additional qualifications in Business Analytics, Project Management, and Executive Coaching.

Find out more about his work and writing at **tolaoladiji.xyz**.

keep going.

Thank you for reading. Emotional wellness is a journey, and you have already taken a step.

- Share this book with one person who could use it.
- If it helped you, a short review means a great deal.
- Read more of my work and writing online.

Tola Oladiji

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